Internal Communication Professionalism

From organizational history to professional practice

Internal communication has a longer and more complex history than a simple story of newsletters evolving into digital channels. The webinar draws on historical research tracing organized communication with employees from the late nineteenth century to the present. Its central argument is that internal communication has repeatedly changed in response to wider social, economic and management shifts. Organizations have used it to address practical challenges such as workforce stability, changing expectations of employees, organizational objectives and culture.

The historical account also challenges easy origin stories. For example, the presenter cautions against describing *The Lowell Offering* as the first company magazine: it was not produced by a company for its employees. The broader lesson is to define internal communication carefully and verify historical claims against evidence.

The discussion then turns to whether internal communication is a profession, or a field still undergoing professionalization. The speakers describe a substantial practitioner community, but point to comparatively low participation in professional bodies, formal qualifications and structured continuing development. They also identify a gap between what professional bodies define as good practice and what employers and recruiters know to look for.

What this means for practice

- Understand the organizational need behind communication work and explain how the function contributes to it.
- Treat professional development, shared standards and clearer recruitment expectations as part of strengthening the field.
- Use history to question assumptions about the role, rather than treating current channels or titles as inevitable.

The webinar presents internal communication as both a response to organizational needs and a practice whose future depends on practitioners making its contribution understood.

Source: “History of Internal Communication and what it means for current and future practice” transcript.